DIGITAL LITERACY CASE STUDY REPORT

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CSE HEALTH INFORMATICS

PART A: CASE STUDY ON UPI/ONLINE PAYMENT FRAUD

UPI (Unified Payments Interface) fraud is a rapidly growing cybercrime where attackers trick users into authorizing fraudulent transactions. It typically begins with the fraudster contacting the victim via phone, SMS, or messaging apps, often pretending to be a bank representative, delivery agent, or buyer.

A common step-by-step method starts with the attacker gaining trust by offering a believable story—such as confirming a refund or payment. Next, the victim is asked to "accept" a payment request or scan a QR code. In reality, these actions authorize money to be sent from the victim's account. Sometimes, the fraudster persuades the victim to share sensitive details like OTPs or UPI PINs, claiming it is required to complete a transaction. Once access is granted, the money is quickly transferred to multiple accounts, making recovery difficult.

Targets are usually everyday smartphone users, especially those unfamiliar with digital payment security—such as elderly individuals, small business owners, or first-time UPI users.

The consequences can be severe. Victims may lose significant amounts of money within minutes, often with little chance of recovery. Beyond financial loss, such incidents cause emotional distress, loss of trust in digital systems, and reputational damage in some cases. This type of fraud highlights the importance of digital awareness, as most scams rely on social engineering rather than technical hacking.

PUBLISHED INCIDENT: UPI FRAUD VIA INVESTMENT SCAM (INDIA 2026)

A recent case reported by The Times of India involved a 35-year-old man from Ahmedabad who lost money through a UPI fraud scam.

The victim joined a Telegram group that promised high returns from stock market investments. After gaining his trust, the fraudsters asked him to transfer ₹25,000 to a UPI ID, assuring him that he would receive profits the next day. However, after making the payment, he received no response. Later, the scammers demanded an additional ₹999 as a "withdrawal fee," which he also paid. Despite this, he never received any returns and realized he had been cheated.

The victim then reported the incident to the cybercrime helpline and filed a police complaint. Authorities began investigating by tracing the UPI transactions and mobile numbers used in the fraud.

This case highlights a common UPI fraud pattern where criminals use social engineering and fake investment schemes to trick victims into voluntarily transferring money. It also shows how quickly fraudsters disappear after receiving payments, making recovery difficult.

PART B: "STAY – SAFE ONLINE" CHECKLIST

1. **Use strong, unique passwords**
   Create different passwords for each account and include a mix of letters, numbers, and symbols. Avoid using names or birthdates.

2. **Enable two-factor authentication (2FA)**
   Turn on 2FA for email, social media, and banking apps to add an extra layer of security.

3. **Never share OTPs or PINs**
   Banks and apps will never ask for your OTP, UPI PIN, or passwords—don't share them with anyone.

4. **Be cautious with unknown links and QR codes**
   Don't click suspicious links or scan random QR codes, especially those claiming rewards, refunds, or urgent actions.

5. **Verify before accepting UPI requests**
   Always check the sender's name and purpose before approving any payment request on apps like Google Pay or PhonePe.

6. **Remember: receiving money doesn't require a PIN**
   If someone asks you to enter your UPI PIN to "receive" money, it's a scam.

7. **Avoid public Wi-Fi for sensitive transactions**
   Don’t log into banking or make payments on unsecured networks in cafes or campuses.
8. **Limit personal information on social media**
   Oversharing details like phone numbers, college ID, or location can make you an easy target.

9. **Install apps only from official stores**
   Download apps from trusted sources like Google Play Store and avoid unofficial APK files.

REPORT CYBER CRIME IMMEDIATELY:

If you fall victim to any online fraud:

- Report at: National Cyber Crime Portal (cybercrime.gov.in)
- Call Helpline: **1930** (for immediate financial fraud assistance)